the private sector, it is a significant shift.

Also responding to the RSH programme, Mumbai-based Max Aerospace and Aviation have tied up with US manufacturer Bell Textron. They propose to assemble the single-engine light helicopter Bell 407GXi, with plans to set up an assembly line in Nagpur.

Maritime requirements are a pressing matter as well. The Naval Utility Helicopter (NUH) programme aims to replace ageing Chetaks used by the Indian Navy and Coast Guard. In August 2025, the MoD issued an RFI for 76 helicopters—51 for the navy and 25 for the Coast Guard—estimated at around Rs 5,000 crore. Expected to have a maximum take-off weight (MTOW) of 5.5 tonnes, these helicopters will support missions including search and rescue, medical evacuation and surveillance. Interestingly, HAL's indigenous Utility Helicopter-Maritime (UH-M), which is designed for an MTOW of 5.8 tonnes, is also a contender, with the navy planning to acquire it when it is available from 2027.

Private sector alternatives are gaining traction here too. For the NUH programme, the Tata-Airbus partnership plans to offer the multi-role H160M. In February, Adani Defence & Aerospace announced a strategic partnership by signing a memorandum of understanding with Leonardo to develop a complete helicopter manufacturing ecosystem in India, from production and assembly to flight training. They are expected to offer the light, twin-engine, multirole AW 169M or similar platforms.

Separately, in 2024, the MoD signed a deal worth Rs 5,083 crore for the procurement of six ALH (Advanced Light Helicopter) Mk-III Maritime Role helicopters for the Coast Guard from HAL. Four were delivered in April 2026.

What does the entry of large private sector players like Tata and Adani and their tie-ups with foreign original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) mean for HAL, the backbone of India's helicopter ecosystem? HAL has designed and manufactured acclaimed platforms such as the Advanced Light Helicopter (ALH) Dhruv and the Light Combat Helicopter (LCH) Prachand. Gopal Sutar, a former HAL official, says that India has entered an elite group of countries capable of end-to-end helicopter design, with HAL at the core of this capability. "These collaborations are bringing new capital, manufacturing practices and global supply chain integration into the Indian ecosystem," Sutar says, adding that this shift is not a threat to HAL but a catalyst. Increased competition, he suggests, will push HAL to improve efficiency, accelerate production and innovate more aggressively.

HAL's future will be anchored in advanced programmes like the Indian Multi-Role Helicopter (IMRH)—a medium-lift helicopter that will replace some of India's large fleet of Russian-origin Mi17 transport copters—being developed in collaboration with French firm Safran, as well as its expansion into the civilian market with platforms like the Dhruv NG. Sutar, however, highlights such challenges as continued dependence on foreign engine supply chains and a looming shortage of skilled manpower.



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– GROUP CAPTAIN R.K. NARANG (RETD)
Senior fellow, Manohar Parrikar Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses

THE CIVIL FRONTIER

While the military demand grabs headlines, the civilian helicopter market may hold greater long-term potential. India operates around 270 registered civil helicopters—a remarkably small fleet for a country of its size. At 0.18 helicopters per million people, India's penetration is far below global benchmarks. The US has about 28 helicopters per million people, while Canada has 68.

The government is working to unlock potential in this sector through policy initiatives. The UDAN 5.1 scheme, for instance, focuses on helicopter routes to improve connectivity in remote and underserved regions. These services will enhance regional transportation, disaster response, emergency medical services, law enforcement and tourism.

Here, too, the industrial partnerships are becoming vital. The Tata-Airbus tie-up to produce the H125 will also manufacture civil versions of the rotorcraft. The Bell 407GXi, AW 169 and H 160 all have civil versions. HAL, too, will offer its Dhruv NG, a light, twin-engine multirole helicopter, representing the company's first foray into the civilian-certified helicopter market.

However, Group Captain R.K. Narang (retd), a senior fellow at the Manohar Parrikar Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses, identifies a key limitation of HAL: its platforms, primarily designed for military use, are often too costly and inefficient for civilian markets.

"I suggest a risk-sharing approach, with HAL holding a 70-80 per cent stake and private players 20-30 per cent. Foreign OEMs should play an advisory role, not dominate manufacturing," he says, warning against over-reliance on licenced production models that lock India into long-term dependence—a familiar pattern in aircraft manufacturing.

India faces a strategic choice about how the huge demand for helicopters will be met. Only progressive policy choices and the ability of stakeholders to collaborate effectively will see India emerge as a global hub for helicopter manufacturing, with strong indigenous design capabilities and a competitive private sector. ■